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SECURITY



US spy chief says UK has dropped its Apple backdoor demand

The U.K. has dropped its demand for special access to Apple's cloud systems, or a "backdoor," following negotiations with the Trump administration, according to U.S. National Intelligence Director Tulsi Gabbard.

"As a result, the U.K. has agreed to drop its mandate for Apple to provide a 'back door' that would have enabled access to the protected encrypted data of American citizens and encroached on our civil liberties," [Gabbard wrote in a post on X](#). She also claimed that she worked along President Donald Trump and Vice President JD Vance in the negotiations.

IMAGE CREDITS: BRYCE DURBIN / TECHCRUNCH

DNI Tulsi Gabbard  

@DNIGabbard · [Follow](#)



Over the past few months, I've been working closely with our partners in the UK, alongside [@POTUS](#) and [@VP](#), to ensure Americans' private data remains private and our Constitutional rights and civil liberties are protected.

As a result, the UK has agreed to drop its mandate for [Show more](#)

7:00 AM · Aug 19, 2025



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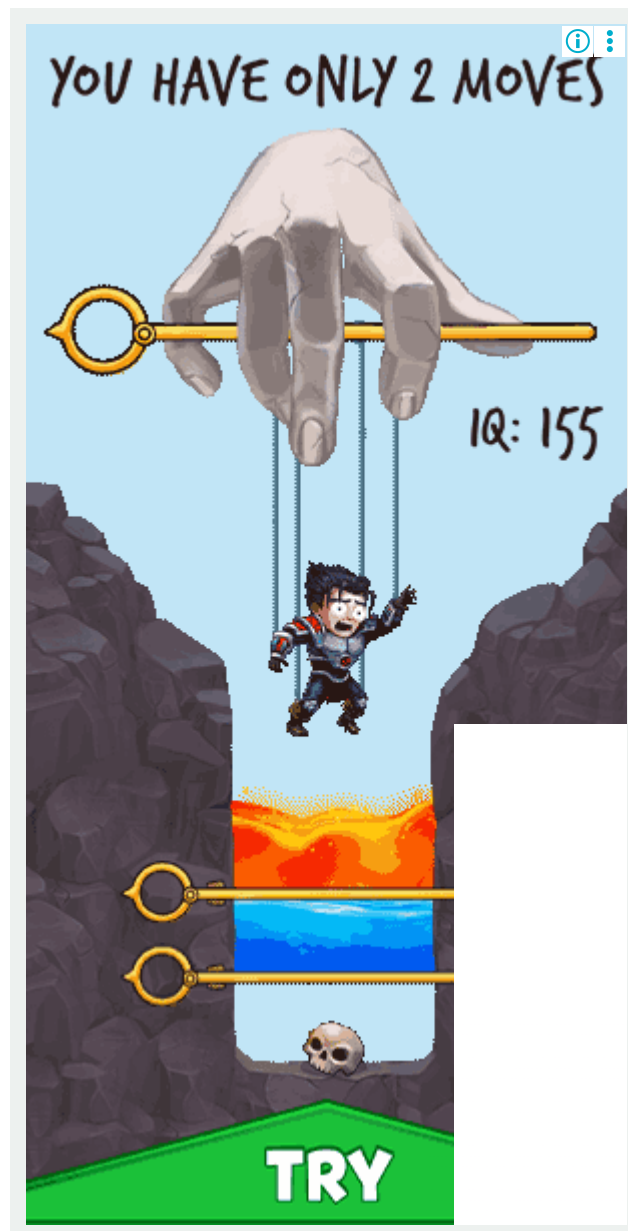


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This is the latest (and unexpected) development in a months-long saga that saw the British government secretly demanding Apple grant its authorities access — essentially asking for a [backdoor](#) — to the encrypted data of iCloud users, effectively anywhere in the world, particularly those who turn on [Advanced Data Protection](#) (or ADP), an opt-in security feature. ADP [turns on end-to-end encryption](#) for iCloud, meaning only the user can access their files stored on Apple’s cloud servers.

The existence of the legal demand was first reported by [The Washington Post](#) in February, which was made under the [U.K.’s Investigatory Powers Act 2016](#), also known as the Snoopers’ Charter. The request [sparked outrage and condemnation](#) from privacy and security experts worldwide, who argued that if the U.K. government obtained what it wanted, it would weaken privacy for the whole world, and also open the door for more governments to make similar demands, even in other companies’ technologies.

[Apple initially responded by removing ADP from the U.K.](#), meaning new users couldn’t turn it on. The company also said it would give guidance to existing users who “will eventually need to disable this security feature.”

In the meantime, Apple also [reportedly challenged the backdoor mandate](#) in court, a case that was initially secret but [was then ruled to be held in public](#).

Apple and the U.K. Home Office, which initiated the demand on behalf of the British government, did not respond to requests for comment.

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Olivia Coleman, the press secretary of the U.S. Office of the Director of National Intelligence, referred to a February letter to Sen. Wyden and Rep. Biggs.

Apple previously told TechCrunch that the company has “never built a backdoor or master key” to any of its products or services and it “never will.”

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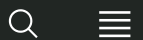
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Substack writers can now direct US readers to (often cheaper) web-based subscriptions on iOS

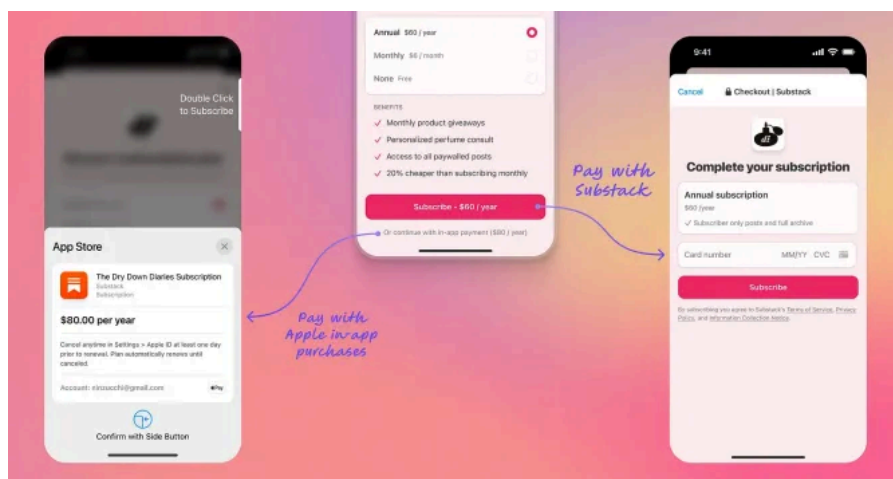
Newsletter subscription platform Substack will begin taking advantage of an option on the U.S. App Store that allows users to make purchases outside of Apple's in-app purchasing system. This

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they want the convenience of Apple's in-app payments system (IAP) or the web payment option, which is now accessible without having to leave the app.



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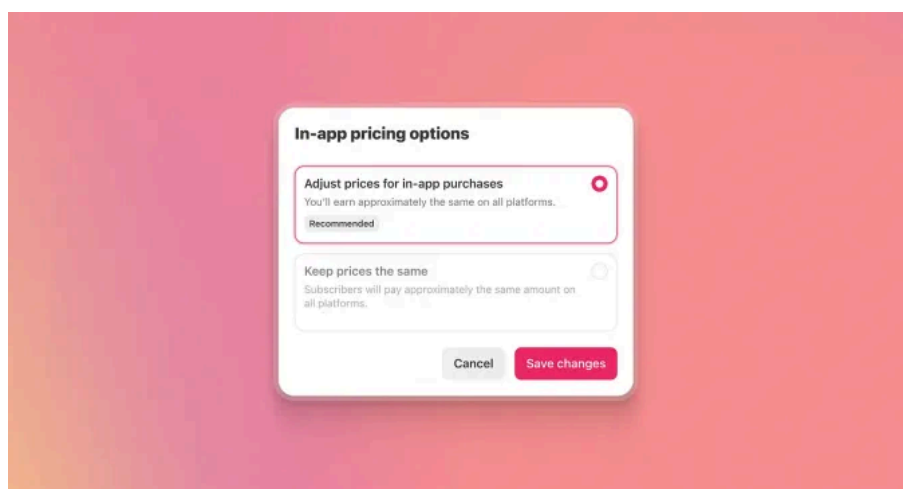
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Substack explains it will automatically adjust its customers' iOS app price higher to account for Apple's fees, allowing creators to take home the same amount of money as a web subscription. However, Substack writers can disable this feature if they choose. (Substack will continue to take its own 10% fee based on the web subscription price, as before.)

The company said in its blog post that it's also offering its writers "migration tools." We originally reported that these could help migrate users from one payments platform to another, but Substack reached out to correct this. Instead, it said that the tools are meant to help creators access billing information for Apple-managed subscriptions if they ever leave the platform.

Currently, more than 30,000 publications on the platform have in-app purchases enabled; Substack says early tests of the expanded set of payment options have driven a boost in paid sign-ups. It did not, however, share specific numbers related to this.



The public launch of the external payments option will only impact new Substack subscriptions. Substack writers don't have to take any action unless they want to lower the prices for those using Apple's payments system.

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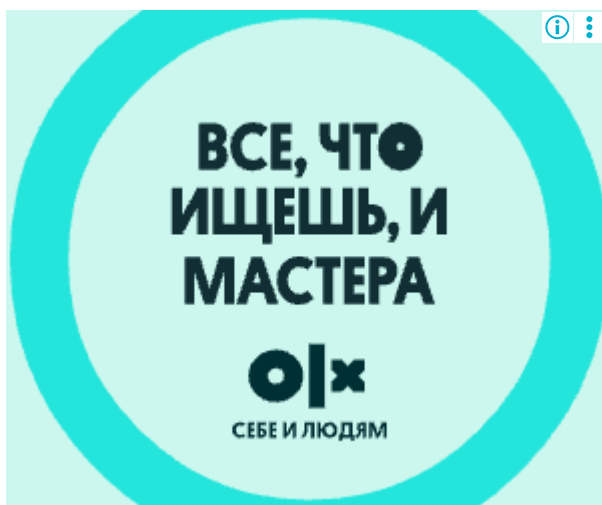
Per Apple's App Store rules, fully opting out of offering IAP is not allowed.

While the changes impact the Substack app in the U.S., the company says it's still evaluating if it makes sense to switch to the more complex rules Apple offers in the EU and U.K. for developers who want to forgo IAP.

Updated after publication to correct and clarify how the migration tools work.

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Sarah Perez

Consumer News Editor | [X](#) [b](#) [m](#) [in](#)

Sarah has worked as a reporter for TechCrunch since August 2011. She joined the company after having...



IMAGE CREDITS: CHENG XIN / GETTY IMAGES

HARDWARE



iPhone 17, the ‘thinnest iPhone ever,’ and everything else we’re expecting out of Apple’s hardware event

Lauren Forristal — 9:20 AM PDT · August 18, 2025

Apple usually announces its new hardware in the fall, and this year is likely no different. The event is reported to be on September 9, and Apple is expected to release its iPhone 17 lineup, along with updates for the Apple Watch and AirPods.

As always, there are many rumors circulating, including bigger screens and improved cameras for the iPhone 17 models and the introduction of an

ultra-thin iPhone Air that could replace the Plus model.

iPhone 17, 17 Pro, and 17 Pro Max

The iPhone 17 is expected to get a significant makeover to align more closely with the Pro models. It could feature a slightly larger [6.3-inch screen](#), which is an increase of 0.2 inches compared to the iPhone 16, as well as a [120Hz display](#), a substantial upgrade from the current 60Hz. It's also rumored to have a 24-megapixel front camera. It could also come in new colors: purple and green.

iPhone 17: Purple and Green Colors in Testing as Potential New Shade for 2025

Full Article:<https://t.co/jZJJoUHBsfpic.twitter.com/1in8R6dDa5>

— Majin Bu (@MajinBuOfficial) [June 20, 2025](#)

The Pro's upgrades will be noticeable on the back of the phone, rumors suggest. [Conceptual renderings](#) show that the three rear cameras may be arranged in a rectangular bar that extends from one edge of the device to the other. The flash, light sensor, and microphone would be positioned far to the right side. Where the MagSafe charger is, the Apple logo is said to be centered for aesthetic reasons.

Notably, the iPhone 17 Pro may switch materials, potentially replacing the titanium band around the screen with aluminum. This could help Apple reduce costs as well as provide a lighter feel.

The iPhone 17 Pro Max is expected to see fewer upgrades, too, with the most significant change being a slightly thicker body, likely to accommodate a larger battery — which would be a huge win.



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According to [leaker Instant Digital](#), the iPhone 17 is predicted to be priced around \$800, and the Pro Max is expected to have a price tag of \$1,250. New colors for the Pro models potentially include [dark blue and copper](#).

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The Pro model is expected to be priced around \$1,050. However, a [recent leak](#) indicates that there will be fewer storage options compared to the 16 Pro. Users may lose the 128GB option and will only have three choices: 256GB, 512GB, or 1TB, down from the typical four options.

iPhone Air



IMAGE CREDITS:APPLE TRACK

The most widely discussed rumor is that Apple might be introducing its slimmest phone ever, [the iPhone Air](#), which may replace the iPhone Plus.

This rumored device is said to have a profile thickness of 5.5 mm, making it about 0.08 inches thinner than current iPhones. It'll also feature a 6.6-inch screen.

This move appears to be Apple's response to the trend of slimmer smartphones, following in the footsteps of other companies like Samsung and Huawei. The iPhone Air could potentially outshine the Samsung Galaxy S25 Edge, which measures 5.8 mm thick. Additionally, it may pave the way for [Apple's long-rumored foldable phone](#), predicted to launch in September 2026.

While the thin design is stylish, it would come with some compromises. Based on the [renders](#) we've seen, the Air is expected to have only one rear camera lens, unlike the Plus, which has two. There are also [rumors](#) that there may not be enough space for a speaker at the bottom, meaning the only audio source could be the front earpiece at the top.

Reports suggest the device will be priced at \$950 and will be available in black, silver, and light gold.

Apple Watch Series 11, Ultra 3, and SE 3

IMAGE CREDITS:APPLE

After a two-year wait, there are various rumors surrounding the Apple Watch Ultra 3, suggesting it will undergo significant changes. These may include faster charging speeds, 5G support, and satellite connectivity. Additionally, it's speculated that the watch will feature a [larger display](#).

One of the most exciting potential upgrades for both the Ultra 3 and Series 11 is the incorporation of blood pressure monitoring capabilities. This feature would notify users if their blood pressure levels are too high or too low. Apple is also considering adding a sleep apnea feature. However, according to Bloomberg's Mark Gurman, the company [may need to delay the release of these features for further tweaks](#).

Apple recently announced that a [redesigned blood oxygen feature](#) is rolling out to some Series 8, 10, and Ultra watches. This leads us to think the Ultra 3 may also get the capability, but the company didn't mention if it would be available in the watchOS 26 in its announcement.

The third generation of Apple Watch SE isn't expected to receive major updates, aside from

possibly a larger display. There continue to be reports of a plastic version being introduced, according to Gurman.

Rumored prices for the watches are: \$250 for the Apple Watch SE 3, \$400 for the Series 11, and \$800 for the Ultra 3.

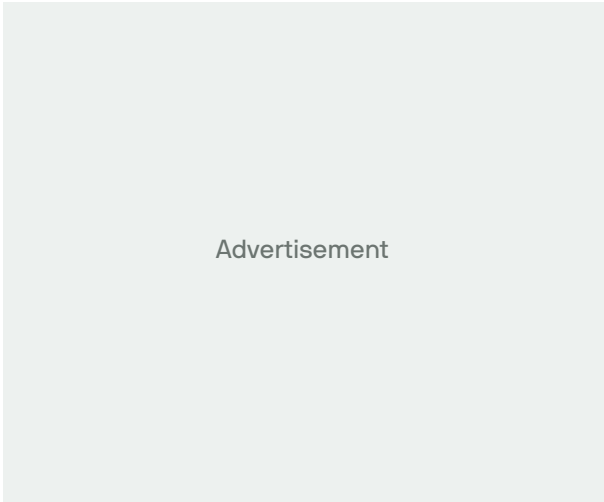
AirPods Pro 3

IMAGE CREDITS:APPLE

After the release of the AirPods Pro 2 in 2022, it's about time for an upgrade, and Apple might just be ready to deliver. [Rumors](#) suggest that the AirPods Pro 3 will feature a sleeker design, touch-sensitive controls, smaller earbuds, and a slimmer case. Additionally, the H3 chip is expected to enhance active noise cancellation and adaptive audio.

This story has been updated to include additional rumors.

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Lauren Forristal
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Lauren covers media, streaming, apps and platforms at TechCrunch....

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